

Applications closed

The Australian Government announced the \$20 million Drought Resilience Innovation Challenges Pilot Program in the 2024–25 Budget.

The program adopts a challenge-based approach that supports innovative solutions to address complex and multi-dimensional challenges imposed by drought and climate impacts. It will fund projects that address one of the following challenges:

- Advancing Natural Capital and Biodiversity for Drought Preparedness and Resilience
- Innovating Water Management for Enhanced Drought Resilience in Australian Agriculture
- National Innovation for Enhancing Community Resilience to Drought in Australian Agricultural Regions

Grant recipients will investigate the effectiveness of high-impact and evidence-driven innovations, that have achieved proof of concept, over two years to increase drought resilience.

Projects will use a consortium of project partners that include farmers or farmer-led organisations.

Drought Resilience Innovation Challenges Pilot Program recipients have been announced.

Selected projects include:

Lead organisation	Project location	Project name
Arca Sustainability Pty Ltd	WA	Farm Forward, Building Drought and Climate Resilience in Western Australia's Broadacre Sector
Australian Fodder Industry Association Limited	NSW & VIC	Transforming Australia's Fodder System. A Collaborative Network for Tough Times
Berries Australia Limited	NSW, QLD, VIC & WA	Bioreactors - Turning runoff into a resource for the protected cropping berry industry
Deakin University	VIC	Building Drought Resilience Through Simulation-Based Learning for Farmers and Rural Communities
Department of Energy Environment and Climate Action	VIC	Optimisation of production and on farm demonstration of beneficial microbes to alleviate drought stress in cereal crops
Desert Channels Queensland Ltd	QLD	RAINS - Resilient Agriculture through Innovation in Native Seeds
James Cook University	QLD	CLOVER - Climate-smart Optimisation for Valuable & Efficient Irrigation
Mallee Sustainable Farming Ltd	NSW, SA & VIC	Accelerating the adoption of farmer led intercropping and multi species innovations in southern Australia's fragile low rainfall environments

Molongghip & District Enterprises Pty Ltd	NSW, QLD, SA & VIC	Transformative AI-Driven Soil Microbiome Analysis and Customised Biofertiliser Development
Outback Academy Australia Limited	NSW, SA, TAS, VIC & WA	Thriving Country Thriving Communities - Traditional Ecological Knowledge Meets New Science and Technologies to Support Drought Resilience
Riverine Plains Incorporated	NSW, SA, VIC & WA	WaterSmart Decisions - Scaling Farmer Confidence in Water Use Efficiency Technologies
Seed Force Pty Ltd	NSW, SA, VIC & WA	SowSure - A Farmer-Led National Trial of Crop Establishment Protection for Drought Resilience
The University of Newcastle	NSW & WA	Hydro Harvester Pilot Program

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/agriculture-land/farm-food-drought/drought/future-drought-fund/drought-resilience-innovation-challenges>